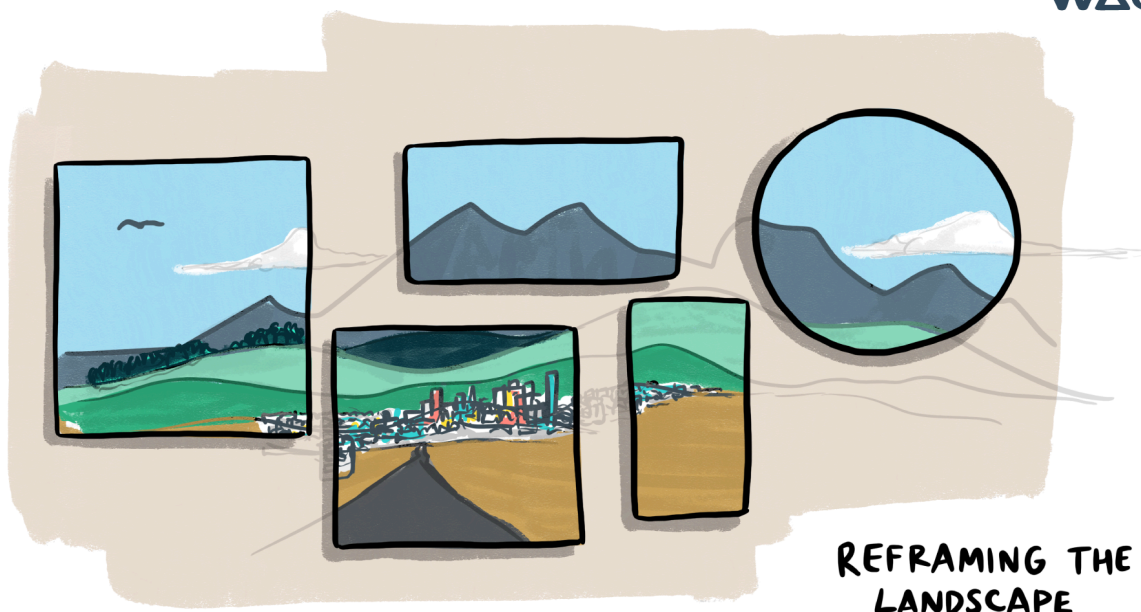


Reframing Recognition: strategies for success in going beyond microcredentials

WAO



Q VISUAL THINKERY

Meta

Audience

- **Educators and trainers:** Teachers, professors, and training professionals in K-12, higher education, and vocational training institutions can benefit from understanding and implementing Open Recognition to validate and showcase their students' skills and accomplishments.
- **Community leaders and organisers:** Individuals who lead or manage clubs, associations, or community organisations can use Open Recognition to acknowledge their members' contributions, achievements, and growth.

- **HR and L&D professionals:** Human Resources managers and Learning & Development specialists can leverage Open Recognition to recognize employees' skills and professional development, enhancing engagement and fostering a culture of continuous learning.
- **Non-profit organisations and NGOs:** Staff and volunteers in non-profit organisations and NGOs can benefit from Open Recognition to showcase their efforts, skills, and impact in the communities they serve.
- **Professional associations:** Professional organisations can use Open Recognition to certify members' skills, knowledge, and expertise, setting industry standards and promoting professional development.

Where to promote this course

- **Social media platforms:** Share the course on Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn, and other relevant social media platforms to reach a wider audience. Use targeted hashtags and join relevant groups or communities to maximise visibility.
 - **Blog posts and articles:** Write blog posts or articles related to Open Recognition, Open Badges, or Verifiable Credentials to generate interest and direct readers to the course.
 - **Education and training websites:** Promote the course on popular education, training, or professional development websites and platforms, where potential participants are likely to be searching for learning opportunities.
 - **Email marketing:** Send targeted email campaigns to existing contacts, such as educators, HR professionals, or community leaders who may be interested in the course.
 - **Webinars and workshops:** Host webinars or workshops on Open Recognition-related topics to introduce the concept and invite participants to join the course.
 - **Networking events and conferences:** Attend or present at industry events, conferences, and meetups to discuss the benefits of Open Recognition and invite interested attendees to enrol in the course.
 - **Collaborations and partnerships:** Partner with relevant organisations, professional associations, or community groups to co-promote the course and extend its reach to their networks.
-

Overview

Welcome to the Reframing Recognition course! This course comprises three emails plus a follow-up in which you'll learn about how to go beyond microcredentialing to issue Open Badges in a way that's compatible with 'Open Recognition'. Our goal is to provide you with a solid foundation, combining academic rigour with practical application.

Here's an outline of the course:

1. Introduction to Open Recognition
 - What do we mean by 'recognition'?
 - Let's define terms
 - Further reading
2. Open Recognition in practice
 - The role of Open Badges in Open Recognition
 - Open Recognition implementation strategies
 - Further reading
3. Practical Steps to Implement Open Recognition
 - Assessing Your Needs
 - Choose the Right Tools
 - Design Meaningful Badges and Recognition Pathways

We hope that you'll find this course both informative and engaging. Each email will include additional resources, case studies, and practical examples to help you understand and apply the concepts presented. If you have any questions or need clarification, feel free to reach out to us.

Email 1 - Introduction to Open Recognition

Subject: Reframing Recognition (1) - Introduction

Dear [Name],

Welcome to the first email of the Reframing Recognition course! In this email, we will introduce you to Open Recognition and technologies that can help raise awareness and appreciation of all kinds of talents, skills and aspirations. We'll provide an overview of the key terms and concepts you'll encounter throughout this course, namely **Open Recognition**, **Open Badges**, and **Verifiable Credentials**.

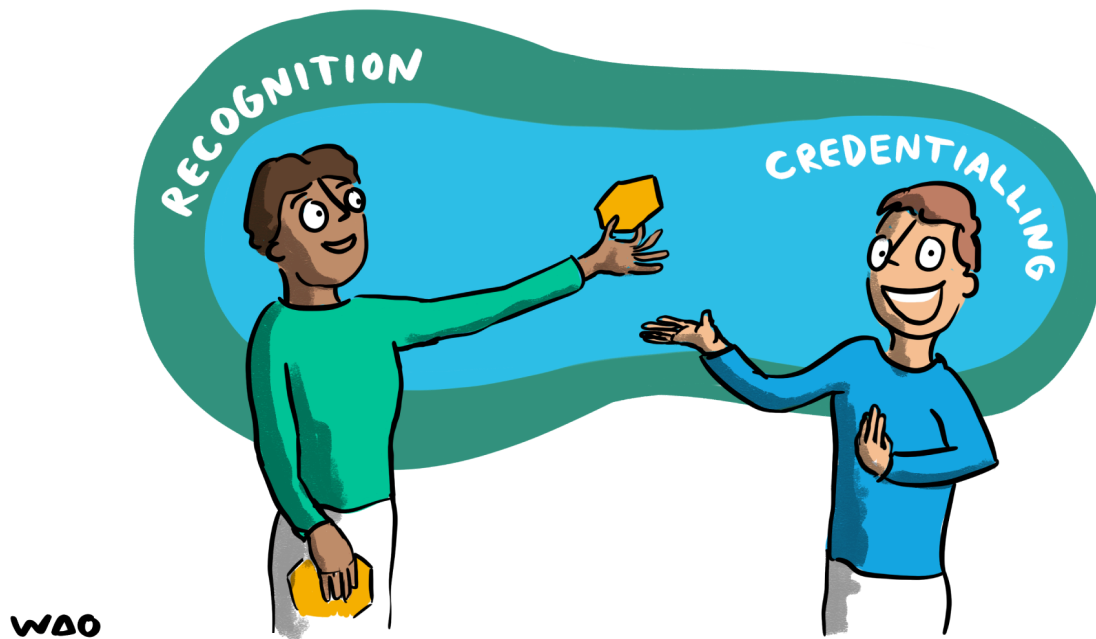


Image credit: CC BY-NC [Visual Thinkery](#) for WAO

What do we mean by ‘recognition’?

Recognition is about appreciating someone's skills, knowledge, or achievements. This can be done in many ways, including with certificates, diplomas, or other items. Traditional recognition usually focuses on formal education and professional growth, but it might miss other types of learning.

Open Recognition illuminates the entire stage of learning, appreciating all kinds of achievements and experiences. It uses digital tools, like Open Badges, to make it easier and more flexible for people to show their different skills and experiences, ensuring no one remains in the dark. By using Open Recognition, organisations and communities can support learning throughout life and give everyone a fair chance to grow in their personal and work life, shining a light on every accomplishment.

Here's a useful definition:

“Open Recognition is the awareness and appreciation of talents, skills and aspirations in ways that go beyond credentialing. This includes recognising the rights of individuals, communities, and territories to apply their own labels and definitions. Their frameworks may be emergent and/or implicit.”

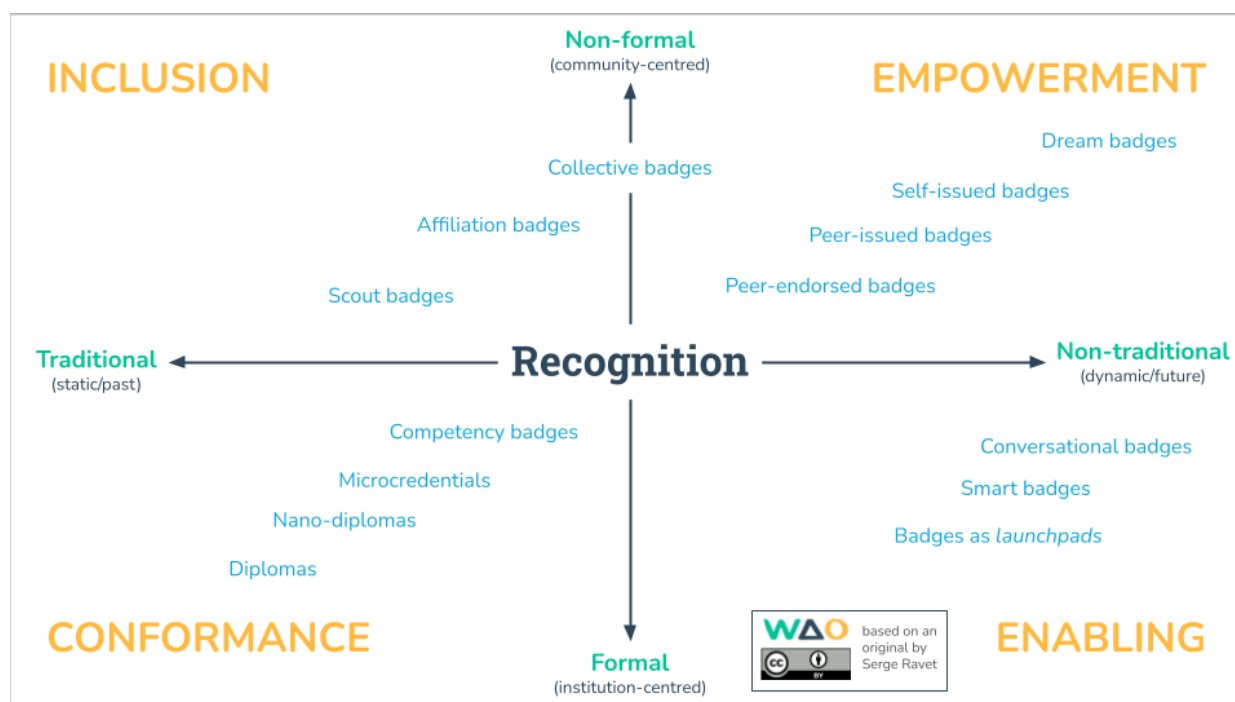


Image credit: CC BY [WAO](#) based on an original by [Serge Ravet \(ORA\)](#)

Let's define terms

While we're defining Open Recognition, let's also look at what we mean by other key terms we'll come across in this email course:

- Microcredentials** — a form of specialised, focused learning typically offered outside of traditional degree programmes. They are designed to help individuals acquire specific skills or knowledge in a particular area, often to meet immediate needs or gaps in the job market. They are usually offered by further or higher education institutions, and/or employers.
- Open Badges** — a 'web standard' way of representing an individual's skills, achievements, or qualifications. Originally developed by the Mozilla Foundation, the standard is now stewarded by a non-profit called 1EdTech. Open Badges are designed to be shareable, verifiable, and customisable. They can be issued by anyone for anything.

In the upcoming emails, we'll dive deeper into these concepts and explore their practical applications. The table below helps explain how Microcredentials and Open Recognition both use Open Badges, but in different ways.

	Microcredentials	Open Recognition badges
Focus	Specific skills and competencies	Lifelong learning and varied experiences
Issuing body	Educational institutions & businesses	Any individual or organisation
Assessment	Formal, often tied to specific courses	Formal, informal, non-formal, or unassessed
Recognition	Mostly academic / professional focused	Broad societal recognition
Relationship with formal education	Supplemental to formal degrees	Can be integrated or standalone
Value proposition	'Alternative' to traditional degrees	Inclusive recognition of lifelong learning
Barriers to entry	Potentially high (cost, time,, etc.)	Low, or none

Image credit: CC BY [WAO](#)

Further reading

For more on this subject, check out the following resources:

- [What is Open Recognition. anyway?](#)
- [Open Recognition is for every type of learning](#)
- [Open Recognition: Towards a Practical Utopia](#)

Suggested activity: Join the Community!

Head to [badges.community](#) and join a global group of people looking to reframe recognition. Don't forget to tell them you arrived there via this course. You may also want to have a look at the work of the [Open Recognition Alliance](#) 😊

Stay tuned for the next email, where we'll explore Open Recognition in practice!

Could your organisation do with more in-depth information or creation workshops? We Are Open runs tailored programmes with organisations of every size. [Get in touch](#) to find out more!



All content released under a [Creative Commons Attribution](#) license (CC BY) by [We Are Open Co-op](#), except where otherwise stated.

Email 2 - Open Recognition in practice

Subject: Reframing Recognition (2) - Open Recognition in practice

Dear [Name],

Welcome to the second email of the Reframing Recognition course! In this instalment, we will:

- Recap the concept of Open Recognition
- Explain its relevance in today's world
- Give examples of Open Recognition in practice
- Suggest strategies for implementing Open Recognition within organisations and communities.
- Examine the role of Open Badges in Open Recognition.

Let's get started!

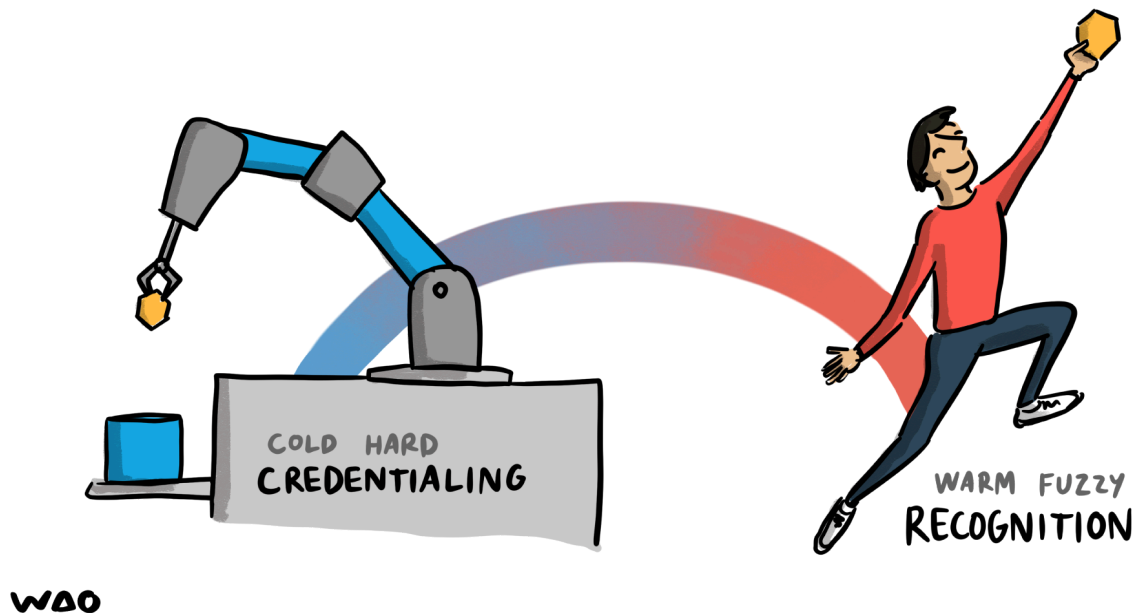


Image credit: CC BY-NC [Visual Thinkery](#) for WAO

The relevance of Open Recognition

As our world becomes more interconnected, the nature of work and learning continues to evolve. As a result, there's a growing need for more flexible and accessible ways to recognise skills and competencies. Open Recognition addresses this need by fostering a culture of lifelong learning which empowers people to showcase their unique talents, skills and aspirations.

In addition, Open Recognition encourages people and communities to be recognised *on their own terms* in ways that go beyond credentialing. This means that individuals, communities, and territories can come up with their own labels and definitions – even if these don't fit neatly into a 'framework'.

Open Recognition can be implemented in various ways, including:

- Community groups issuing one-off, ad-hoc badges to recognise valuable contributions by members, and to encourage new volunteers.
- Educational institutions incorporating informal and non-formal recognition into their credentialing systems, reflecting a more holistic view of their students that goes beyond the traditional classroom setting.
- Employer-led programmes acknowledging skills and competencies learned through on-the-job training or informal learning experiences, mirroring the true value of workplace learning.

The role of Open Badges

[Open Badges](#) make Open Recognition possible. They enable organisations and individuals to issue, share, and verify digital tokens that serve as forms of recognition. By embracing the Open Badges standard, organisations can contribute to a more inclusive and open ecosystem for recognising and valuing skills.

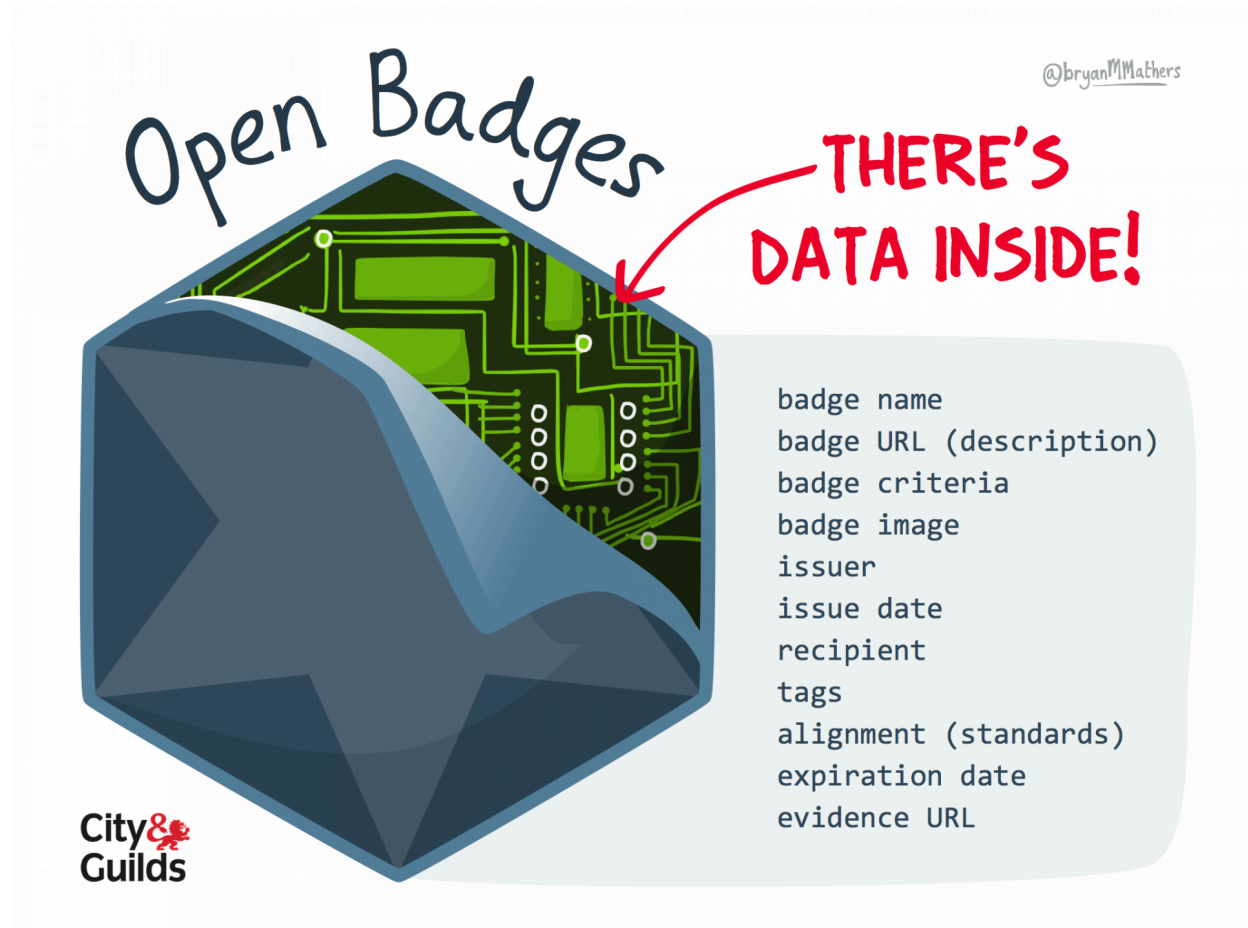


Image credit: CC BY-NC [Bryan Mathers](#)

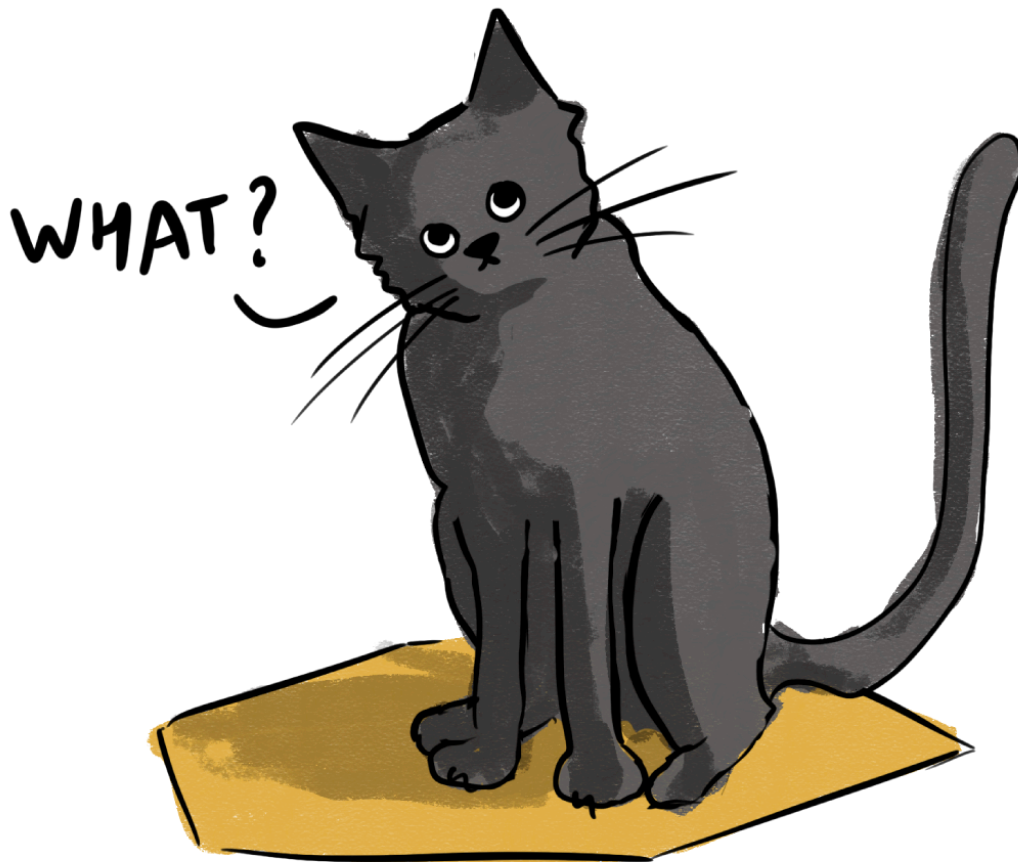
You may have come across Open Badges before, but if not, check out the image below, which explains how metadata is hard-coded into the digital image. You may also want to check out the (mini!) [Badge Curious](#) and [Build-a-Badge](#) courses to dive into this in a bit more detail.

Getting started with Open Recognition

As with any new initiative, it's important not to just rush in but to plan what it is you're trying to achieve by implementing Open Recognition practices within your organisation or community.

Consider the following:

1. **Assess the needs and goals:** Determine your organisation or community's requirements in terms of recognition. What do people want to be recognised for? What is it useful to recognise and encourage within your community or organisation?
2. **Collaborate with others:** Work together with relevant people within your organisation or community to come up with positive and productive ways of recognising people.
3. **Choose the right tools:** Select a suitable system for issuing, sharing, and displaying Open Badges. For example, some badging systems are narrowly focused on the needs of organisations issuing microcredentials, whereas others allow for a more holistic approach.
4. **Recruit early adopters:** Publicise the idea and ask for enthusiastic volunteers to test your ideas for Open Recognition badges. Find ways in which they can give you open and honest feedback about their value.
5. **Foster a culture of recognition:** Promote the value of diverse talents, skills and aspirations. Encourage your organisation or community to recognise one another not only with badges but more generally in terms of affirmations that may *lead* to badges.



WAO

Image credit: CC BY-NC [Visual Thinkery](#) for WAO

Further reading

For more on this subject, check out the following resources:

- [Open Recognition Framework](#)
- [The Bologna Open Recognition Declaration \(BORD\)](#)
- [Towards an Ethical Framework for Open Recognition](#)

Suggested activity: Open Recognition Brainstorming

Think about potential Open Recognition initiatives that could be implemented in your organisation or community.

Reflect on the following questions:

1. What types of learning contexts do you want to acknowledge?
2. How can Open Recognition add value to these learning contexts?
3. What kinds of knowledge, skills, and behaviours are important to your organisation or community?
4. How can Open Recognition help highlight these?
5. How will you ensure that your recognition methods are inclusive and accessible?

Share your ideas at [badges.community](#) for feedback and discussion.

Stay tuned for the next email, where we'll find out more the basics of Open Badges!

Could your organisation do with more in-depth information or creation workshops? We Are Open runs tailored programmes with organisations of every size. [Get in touch](#) to find out more!



All content released under a [Creative Commons Attribution](#) license (CC BY) by [We Are Open Co-op](#), except where otherwise stated.

Email 3 - Practical Steps to Implement Open Recognition

Subject: Reframing Recognition (3) - Practical next steps

Dear [Name],

Welcome to the third and final email of the Reframing Recognition course! This time around, we will provide practical steps for implementing Open Recognition.



WAO

Image credit: CC BY-NC [Visual Thinkery](#) for WAO

Assessing your needs

Before implementing Open Recognition, it's important to understand your organisation or community's needs and aspirations. You can do this by determining what to celebrate, as well as the best ways to do so.

Ask yourself these questions:

- What specific talents, skills and aspirations do you want to celebrate within your community?
- How can badges help foster learning and personal growth for your organisation or community's members?
- Who are the people most invested in this process, and what do they hope to gain from Open Recognition?

Choosing the right tools

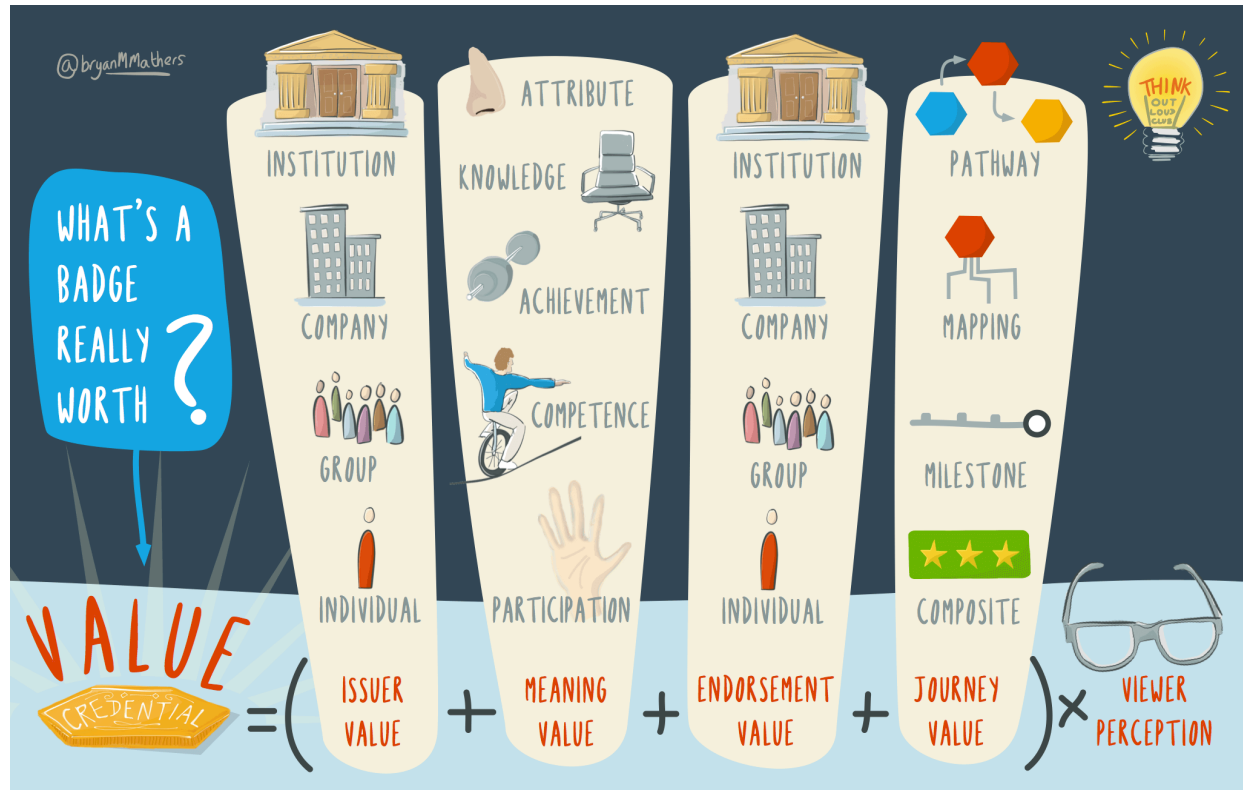
To issue Open Recognition badges you will need a badge issuing platform. There are many of these, and your context is likely to be different to others. For that reason, instead of making a single recommendation, we suggest that you check out [Badge Wiki](#).



Image credit: CC BY [WAO](#)

However, before you get to issuing badges, it's worth thinking holistically about the context into which you're recognising others. The [badge canvas](#) above foregrounds recognition practices, linking them to badges. You might not need to do this for every badge issued in your organisation or community, but it's a useful place to start.

Designing recognition pathways



Badges for Open Recognition are by themselves valuable and useful. Going one step further and thinking about pathways can be even more powerful. Badges can represent not only knowledge, skills, and understanding, but also behaviours, relationships, and experiences. As the above illustration suggests, you are not in control of every aspect of how a badge is understood, but you can make them relevant, visually appealing, and convey the desired message.

Questions to consider include:

- How can you define the visual and metadata elements of your badges to ensure they are meaningful?.
- What are some ways in which individuals can make choices in terms of next steps on a recognition pathway?
- Where can you find opportunities to paint a richer picture of individuals and communities, to enable them to show their various facets?

It might be that the pathways you provide to your organisation or community are prescriptive. That is to say that, based on what you know, there are a series of pre-defined steps that individuals can go through. Or it could be that the pathways you provide are descriptive. In this case, the pathways are created after the fact by what people actually do. It's the difference

between offering a prospectus and someone writing their autobiography. Of course, the two approaches aren't mutually exclusive!

Further reading

For more on this subject, check out the following resources:

- [Badge Wiki](#)
- [Open Recognition Alliance resources](#)
- [Open Recognition is for Everybody \(ORE\) community](#)

Suggested activity: Open Recognition Roadmap

Create a roadmap for implementing Open Recognition practices in your organisation or community, based on what you have learned from the course. This could begin with a mindmap, but then move to a timeline which prioritises what to do first. Share your ideas at [badges.community](#) for feedback and discussion.

Could your organisation do with more in-depth information or creation workshops? We Are Open runs tailored programmes with organisations of every size. [Get in touch](#) to find out more!



All content released under a [Creative Commons Attribution](#) license (CC BY) by [We Are Open Co-op](#), except where otherwise stated.

Follow-up email

Subject: Reframing Recognition: Follow-up

Dear [Name],

Congratulations on completing WAO's short Reframing Recognition course! It hopefully served as an *introduction* to Open Recognition, rather than the last word, but we'd love your feedback! How would you like to see this improve? What questions do you still have?

While we're here, this course is free but not cheap to create, maintain, or run. If you've found value in it, why not support this course on Open Collective?



In addition, it might be that you need some help in getting started with Open Recognition in your organisation or community. Here are some of the ways in which we'd be happy to help:

Needs Assessment and Strategic Planning

We'll work closely with you to evaluate your organisation or community's objectives, identify opportunities, and develop a comprehensive Open Recognition strategy that aligns with your goals and vision.

Platform Selection and Integration

There's a plethora of platforms out there, so we'll help you choose the right tools and platforms for issuing, managing, and displaying Open Badges and Verifiable Credentials.

Badge Design and Recognition Pathways

We'll collaborate with you to create meaningful and visually appealing badge designs and establish clear recognition pathways that define the criteria for earning and issuing badges.

Training and Capacity Building

Build the necessary skills and knowledge within your organisation or community through workshops and training sessions. We'll help you effectively manage your digital initiatives, ensuring long-term success and sustainability.

Ongoing Support and Evaluation

We'll provide ongoing support to address challenges, troubleshoot issues, and ensure your Open Recognition initiatives hit the mark. We'll also help you track the impact of your projects and use our expertise to help you identify areas for growth and development.

If you're interested in exploring how we can help, please [get in touch](#)! Initial conversations are always free of charge.



All content released under a [Creative Commons Attribution](#) license (CC BY) by [We Are Open Co-op](#), except where otherwise stated.